

Feature

Can you really have a home that can not only take care of itself, but you too? Our take on home automation.

Origins

From Babylonians to today's cryptographers, we delve deeper into the origins of algorithms.



WE NEED TO TALK...

Talking to your gadgets has never been more natural

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There was a time when talking to a machine in public might have resulted in you being declared insane and taken to an asylum. From that point in time, we have reached somewhere where it is totally acceptable to have long conversations with a witty virtual assistant on your phone while completely ignoring the people around you. Almost every major software platform now has voice recognition in one form or another, be it virtual assistants or mere dictation. We have achieved a lot on how we speak to our smart gadgets now. But are we really there yet?

We're talking more. But Why?

Before we really delve into the quality of digital assistants and voice recognition on

different platforms, we need to stop and take stock of what really facilitates the current state of this technology. At a broad overview level, everything from better audio formats to higher quality microphones have helped in making digital voice interaction a valid and acceptable option. But the technology wasn't really waiting for those parts.

When it comes to the hardware side, the growth of voice assistants on phones as a platform is quite predictable, considering that we have always been looking for ways to replace the hard to use phone keyboards, trying everything from larger screens to new ways for typing. Now, for voice recognition to truly evolve on phones, there was a need for processing power. Google started with the voice search app, with the concept of offloading most of the processing to its servers. Gradually, smartphone processors gained power exponentially and now we have phones that can take care of the pro-

cessing locally as well, especially for basic, repetitive tasks.

Although hardware improvements have been crucial, the improvements on the software side have been way more significant. The field of artificial intelligence has grown in leaps and bounds in recent years. Rather than exactly catching the sound and transcribing it, modern day virtual assistant AI works on a predictive model where it checks the probability of a certain sound being a certain word to guess what you are saying. And newer abilities are being added every day where the AI can do things like understanding your mood and learning your preferences.

Although the innovations mentioned above are quite significant, let us not forget that necessity is the mother of invention. In the past years, the devices that can handle voice interaction have not only been limited to phones and computers. A lot more catego-